PRAYER SERIES AT TIFERET EYAL

What Is Prayer? If God Knows What We Need, Why Pray?

Prayer Series, Part 1

Series: Prayer Series (Tiferet Eyal, 2021-22) **Shiur:** Part 1 of the six-part Prayer Series, given by Dayan Daniel Kada on Zoom for Tiferet Eyal, Tuesday 23 November 2021

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Introduction: Back to Basics

The Rabbi opened a new kind of series, one that "goes down to the root of what we do on a daily basis." We often discuss important topics, he said, but forget the basics precisely because we are so used to doing them. Tefillah is something we do a lot, yet we don't always recognise its value, its importance and its role in our lives.

There are people who have prayed for thirty, forty, fifty or sixty years, day in and day out, "as halacha demands, correctly so," who still could not explain what the purpose of tefillah is, why they pray, or which parts of the prayer are the more important ones. Of course there are other advantages to coming to the Bet HaKnesset: we socialise, and maybe have a nice kiddush. "But the reality is that we're coming to pray." So we need to understand three things: **what** we are doing, **why** we are doing it, and **how** it should be done.

The plan for the series

The series examines tefillah historically, and also tries to understand what is actually happening at each part of the prayer:

Shiur	Topic
1	Origins of prayer, women and prayer, how prayer works, and how prayer squares with Hashem's knowledge of what we need
2	Pesukei DeZimrah and Nishmat: their origins and their importance relative to the rest of tefillah
3	The Shema and its blessings: revelation and redemption, and how they connect
4	The Amidah, the root of prayer, and the customs surrounding its repetition
5	Tefillah and Torah: why we read the Torah in the middle of prayer, and children and women reading from the Torah
6	Musaf and the completion of prayer

There would be no shiur the following week, which was Hanukkah.

Part 1: Where Does Prayer Come From?

Prayer throughout the Torah

The concept of people praying runs through the whole Torah, and the Rabbi pointed to the parashiyot read in recent weeks:

- **Avraham** prays that the cities of Sedom should be saved.
- **Yitzchak** is praying in the field in the afternoon when Rivka arrives.
- **Yaakov**, at the beginning of Vayishlach, prays: **הצילני נא**, "Please save me" from my brother.
- **Moshe** prays for his sister Miriam when she is struck with tzara'at.
- **Hannah** prays for a child.

So tefillah was clearly central in the lives of our patriarchs and matriarchs. Yet seemingly nowhere does Hashem tell us explicitly in the Torah that there is a mitzvah to pray.

The Rambam and the Ramban

This is a famous and central argument between **the Rambam** (Maimonides) and **the Ramban** (Nachmanides): is there a Torah obligation to pray?

The Rambam points to the Gemara at the beginning of Masechet Ta'anit, which quotes the verse we say every day in the Shema, to love Hashem **ולעבדו בכל לבבכם**, "and to serve Him with all your heart":

> What is the service of the heart? You must say, this is **איזו היא עבודה שבלב? הוי אומר זו תפלה**.prayer

We can serve Hashem with our hands, with our lips, with our minds. What service comes from the heart? Tefillah. So for the Rambam, when the Torah commands us to serve Hashem with our hearts, that is a biblical obligation to pray, and he counts it among the 613 mitzvot.

The Rabbi drew out the implication. People often equate prayer with saying words and gathering together, but for the Gemara and the Rambam, **prayer is an activity of the heart**: "with the heart and in the heart." You cannot just recite words without understanding them. He quoted the prophet Yeshayahu, where Hashem complains that "with their lips they honoured Me, but their heart was far from Me." Hashem is not interested in that. "The essence of prayer isn't what you say, but how you say it, and the engagement of the heart in the words of the prayer."

The Ramban argued, pointing to a different Gemara in Berachot. Rabbi Elazar says: if you are in doubt whether you read the Shema, you must read it again; if you are in doubt whether you prayed, you do not pray again, and that is the halacha. You go to sleep at night and can't remember whether you said Shema: you say it again. But a doubt about whether you prayed? You don't repeat it.

Why the difference? Because of a basic principle:

Doubt about...	Rule
A mitzvah from the Torah (*de'oraita*)	Be stringent and repeat it
A mitzvah from the Hachamim (*derabanan*)	No need to repeat it

So Shema, which is biblical, must be repeated when in doubt, while tefillah, which is not repeated, must be rabbinic.

How does the Ramban deal with the Gemara of "service of the heart"? He concedes that there **is** a Torah obligation to pray **in a time of trouble**: a war, an attack, any kind of tragedy or distress. That is undisputed, even by the Ramban. But the prayers we say on a regular basis are, for him, entirely rabbinic.

The Rabbi found this striking. Ask a Jewish person what is central to Judaism and they will say Shabbat, kashrut, and probably prayer. The High Holy Days are all about prayer. And yet, according to the Ramban, regular prayer is only rabbinic.

The Rambam: from the heart to a fixed text

The Rambam adds an important qualification. Even though prayer is a Torah obligation, the Torah never tells us **how much** to pray. All it says is "service of the heart." So for the Rambam the biblical obligation is **once a day**, at **no specific time**. Morning, afternoon and evening prayers were later rabbinic institutions.

The Rabbi read from the Rambam (Hilchot Tefillah, chapter 1):

It is a positive Torah commandment to pray every day, as it says, "You shall serve Hashem your God." The number of prayers is not prescribed in the Torah, nor is there a specific formula, nor fixed times... When we were exiled among the nations, the speech of each person became a mixture of many tongues, and no one could express himself coherently in any one language... When Ezra and his court saw this, they established eighteen blessings in sequence.

So, said the Rabbi, a set text for prayer is really **a concession**. In essence, we should be praying in our own tongue and our own words. The problem is that we are not always able to express ourselves properly, so Ezra fixed the eighteen blessings to be said daily. And, the Rabbi explained, once there was a fixed text, Ezra also fixed the times: Shacharit and Mincha, twice a day.

"Can you see where we're going? We're going from an obligation of the heart, which is completely free-spirited. It's up to you what you want to say, how you want to say it, when you want to say it... And then it ends up with an obligation two times a day with a set text."

That is how we arrived at today's rigid framework, with exact times for when Shacharit and Mincha may start and end. For the Ramban, by contrast, there never was a biblical obligation. The rabbis established prayer to build our relationship with Hashem, and when they did, they set it for twice a day. For the Rambam, the obligation in its raw form is biblical, while its structure is rabbinic.

Why it is called a Siddur

This, said the Rabbi, is why our prayer book is called a **Siddur**, from the word **seder**, order. It gives order and structure to our prayer. "Really, you don't need a Siddur. You can open your heart and pray wherever you want to pray." But it gives us a structure. "It's important that we never forget: the root of prayer is the heart, and the root of prayer is something which really should be coming spontaneously."

Part 2: Women and Prayer

The Rambam's view has a major consequence. There is a principle that women are exempt from **positive, time-bound mitzvot**, which is why they are exempt from blowing shofar or shaking the lulav. But according to the Rambam, the biblical mitzvah of prayer can be done at **any time** of the day. It is therefore **not time-bound**, and on a biblical level there is no distinction at all between men and women. **This is how the Rambam rules, and the Shulchan Aruch follows him: men and women have an equal obligation to pray.**

Women do not need to pray with a minyan, but those are later details. "People often think prayer is about men," because men make the minyan, lead the service and run it. "But the reality is that women and men have equal obligation to pray." The Rabbi called this "very central to our belief, that women and men have the equal roles of reaching out to HaKadosh Baruch Hu." It is not that the men pray while the women are at home.

The practical halacha

- **The obligation is at least once a day, an Amidah.** A woman can choose Shacharit, Mincha or Arvit.
- The consensus of the poskim is that women are **not** obligated to pray twice a day. Some opinions hold that once the rabbis instituted two prayers, they included women too, so **if a woman can pray twice a day, that is lovely**. But the main view is once a day.
- **In extenuating circumstances**, for example looking after children, lack of time, or being unable to pray in Hebrew or English, one can rely on the recital of **Birkot HaShachar**, from **הנותן לשכוי בינה** until the end of **Birkot HaTorah**. Some hold that this fulfils the bare requirement of tefillah.

In short: in the first instance a woman should pray the Amidah at least once a day. If she cannot, the minimum is Birkot HaShachar.

Part 3: The Four Kinds of Prayer

Before tackling how prayer works, the Rabbi distinguished between the different things we do when we pray. Every part of the prayer, he said, falls into one of **four categories**:

#	Type	What we do	Daily example
1	**Adoration / praise**	Exalt and sanctify Hashem, asking for nothing	**קדוש קדוש קדוש**; "who forms light and creates darkness," who rolls away the night and brings the day
2	**Thanksgiving** (*hoda'ah*)	Thank Hashem for what He has done	**מודים אנחנו לך**; the morning blessings, "who opens the eyes of the blind"
3	**Penitence**	Speak about our own failures and ask forgiveness	**סלח לנו**; Tachanun after the Amidah
4	**Petition** (*bakasha*)	Ask for what we need	The middle blessings of the weekday Amidah

He placed **Hallel**, *hallel vehoda'ah*, more in the category of thanksgiving.

Why the congregation says its own Modim

In the repetition of the Amidah we usually just listen and answer amen. There are two places where the congregation comes in: **Kedushah** (*Kadosh, Kadosh, Kadosh*), which is a new element of the prayer, and **Modim**. When the hazan reaches Modim, we say our own Modim, even though we already said it in our silent Amidah. It is the only part of the Amidah that the congregation says twice. Why?

The hazan is our representative, praying on our behalf. "Well, one thing you can't do on someone else's behalf is thank." You cannot answer amen and say, "I agree with that." Thanksgiving must come from you, so we rely on no messenger for it.

Petition is the smallest part

The fourth kind, petition, is what we usually associate with prayer: "I need to pray now" means "I need to ask God for something." But on Shabbat there is almost no petition at all, and even in a weekday Shacharit only about **ten percent** is actually asking. Pesukei DeZimrah are songs of praise; the Shema and its blessings ask for nothing; only the middle blessings of the Amidah are requests. The Rabbi's challenge: next time you pray, try to find any part of the prayer that doesn't fit one of these four categories.

From the class

- **Is Adon Olam a prayer?** "Not really. Adon Olam is a song." It is not an intrinsic part of tefillah and doesn't really fit any of the four categories, except perhaps praise.
- **Jane** mentioned being encouraged to add her own personal prayers, especially in difficult times. The Rabbi agreed that prayer is about your own heart, but pushed back gently on equating it with asking: "Why can't prayer be where you turn to God in the middle of the day and say, God, thank you so much for everything You've done for me?" Free prayer can be asking, thanking, or admitting, "I was wrong in what I did earlier." A real prayer, as we will see in the Amidah, contains all four elements.

Part 4: The Problem With Asking

The first three types of prayer make sense, said the Rabbi, and the Rishonim were comfortable with them:

- **Praise:** not because Hashem needs our praises, but to remind ourselves that there is a force behind the universe and that He is in charge.
- **Thanksgiving:** we must never be ungrateful. Acknowledging Hashem for the good in our lives makes us more appreciative and grateful people, also towards other human beings.
- **Penitence:** we are human and make mistakes. We need a way to express remorse and say, "I want to change, and I've decided to change."

The one type the medieval Jewish and Islamic philosophers grappled with is **petition**. We believe in a God who is all good, just and benevolent, who wants the best for us. Then whatever situation we are in must be for the best.

"A person falls ill, and suddenly everyone says, let's pray for him. I don't understand. Do we believe God is just? So that means that person fell ill correctly."

So you take out your Tehillim and start praying. For what? Hashem made this person ill or poor, for whatever reason, and that is what is best for him. "Surely we are not changing Hashem's mind when we pray." And we certainly are not saying, "Hashem thinks this is best, but I think not, so let me change His mind." He knows what is best for us and wants what is best for us. So why ask?

Part 5: Rav Yosef Albo's Answer: The Doctor

There are different answers, but the best, said the Rabbi, is that of **Rav Yosef Albo**, the fifteenth-century Spanish philosopher, in **Sefer HaIkarim** (the Book of Principles), **section 4, chapter 18**, "a worthwhile chapter to see."

The parable

A patient goes to the doctor, who tells him he is in a terrible state. After years of neglecting his health, the only way to keep him alive is to **amputate both legs**. The patient accepts that the doctor knows best, but asks: "You've reached this decision based on how I've eaten and lived for years. Give me one month. Let me change my diet, my routine, my exercise."

- After a month: "You look much better. We can get away with amputating **one leg**."
- He becomes even stricter. Next month: **no amputation**, just an operation.
- Next month: **no operation**, just tablets.
- He doesn't want the side effects of tablets, so he keeps going. Six months after the first visit: **no amputation, no operation, no tablets**. "You can go home, you're a healthy, free man."

Did the doctor want the best for his patient? Yes. Did he know what was best? Yes. Did he change his mind six times? Yes. Was he ever mistaken? **No.** "The doctor was changing the diagnosis every month, but was never wrong."

The lesson

"Prayer of petition is transformative. The purpose of prayer of petition is not to get God to change His mind. Rather, it's for the person to change oneself."

Hashem looks at a person and decides that, in his current state, his diagnosis for the coming year is illness. When that person prays, the prayer transforms him. The decree was made on **person X**. "You're now person Y. You've changed your essence, you've changed your identity, therefore you get now a different diagnosis."

The text of the Ikarim

The Rabbi read the passage in translation:

The influences from above come down upon the recipient when he is in a certain degree and state of preparation to receive them. If a person does not prepare himself, he withholds the good from himself. For example, if it has been determined from on high that a person's crop should prosper in a given year, and he neglects to plough or sow his land, then God may bring the most abundant rain, but his crops will not prosper, since he did not plough or sow.

Every good decreed is conditional on a certain degree of right conduct, and every evil decreed is conditional on a certain degree of wickedness or predisposition to it. Albo compares it to a king who decrees that all the uncircumcised in a country should be killed, or should receive gold: anyone who has himself circumcised is no longer included. And to the objection that the divine will cannot be changed by prayer, he answers that the divine will **from the outset** was that the decree should stand if the person stays as he is, and change if he changes.

Part 6: How Does Prayer Transform Us?

The Rabbi gave two ways.

1. Self-scrutiny: the meaning of *lehitpalel*

The verb **להתפלל** is reflexive, from the root **פ־ל־ל**. A *hit-* verb in Hebrew is something you do to yourself: **להתרחץ**, to wash oneself; **להתלבש**, to dress oneself (one of the participants, Eva, supplied examples); **להתרחק**, to distance oneself. The only place in Tanach where the verb is not reflexive is in Tehillim, **ויעמד פינחס ויפלל**, "Pinchas stood up and prayed."

are judges. So *lehitpalel* literally means **to judge yourself, to examine yourself**. When **פלילים** :we ask for something, prayer becomes an opportunity for introspection

- Praying for **wisdom**, the first request of the Amidah: am I doing everything within my capability to attain wisdom?
- Praying for **health**: am I doing everything I can to live healthily?
- Praying for **parnasah**: am I being too lazy?
- Praying **שמע קולנו**, "hear our voice, have mercy on us": am I being merciful and kind to other people?

2. Relationship

When you pray for wisdom, you acknowledge that Hashem is the source of wisdom. Imagine a son who needs money and food and goes to ask his uncle. When the father finds out, he is

hurt: "Why didn't you come and ask me?" We often get upset when people we are close to don't ask us for favours. Asking is a sign of relationship.

The Rabbi cited "the famous idea" of **the snake**. After the sin, the snake was given what seems like the best livelihood: it eats the dust and never has to work again. But it never once needs to ask, so it has no relationship with Hashem. Human beings forge that relationship by asking, and in doing so transform ourselves.

Part 7: Praying for Someone Else

All of this works well when a person prays for himself. But the Rabbi is often asked, "Can you pray for this person?" How does that work?

First: "Nothing beats prayer for yourself. However great the rabbi is, nothing beats prayer for yourself, because ultimately it's down to you."

But when you ask someone to pray for you, the one praying is transformed, raising himself through introspection and relationship. Because we are all intertwined, and that change came about through **your request**, you have an indirect contribution to his transformation. That can bring about a different decree for the person in need.

A caution: "I don't want you to go away from tonight and start thinking about every prayer and trying to measure how much you've changed." This is a broad, philosophical understanding of prayer, not something to calculate each time we pray.

Questions at the End

Did the Jews lead the way in prayer? Every religion has some form of it. Yes, said the Rabbi. Prayer goes back to Avraham, one of the first human beings, at the very beginning, so other religions with the concept of prayer must have taken it from us. But they emphasise different aspects. In Christianity, for example, prayer is very much about the penitential element, recognising one's mistakes. "Prayer is a broad term. There's four different aspects to it."

What about Shema for women? Women are not obligated in Shema, because it is a time-bound mitzvah, said in the morning and evening. It is a good thing to say it and remember Hashem, "but really, if you had a choice between Shema and Amidah, 100% Amidah would be better." (The questioner had first thought the minimum was "the blessings"; the Rabbi clarified that the minimum is the Amidah, with Birkot HaShachar as the substitute when one cannot.)

Summary

1. **Origins:** prayer appears throughout the Torah, from Avraham to Hannah. For **the Rambam**, prayer is a **Torah mitzvah**, *avodah shebalev*, the service of the heart (Ta'anit). For **the Ramban**, regular prayer is **rabbinic**, with a Torah obligation only in times of trouble (from the Gemara in Berachot on a doubt whether one prayed). The halacha follows the Rambam.
2. **From the heart to the Siddur:** the Torah obligation is once a day, at any time, in any words. Ezra fixed eighteen blessings because exile made it hard for people to express themselves, and fixed times followed. A set text is a concession; the root of prayer is the heart.

3. **Women:** since the biblical mitzvah is not time-bound, **women are obligated to pray just like men** (Rambam, Shulchan Aruch): an Amidah at least once a day, or Birkot HaShachar in extenuating circumstances.
4. **Four kinds of prayer:** praise, thanksgiving, penitence and petition. Petition is only about ten percent of Shacharit. We say our own **Modim** because no one can thank on your behalf.
5. **Why ask? Rav Yosef Albo** (Ikarim 4:18): like the doctor whose diagnosis changes as the patient changes, prayer does not change Hashem's mind; it changes **us**, and the decree applies to who we are.
6. **How prayer transforms: lehitpalel** means to judge oneself (self-scrutiny), and asking builds a **relationship** with Hashem (unlike the snake).
7. **Praying for others** works indirectly, but nothing beats praying for yourself.

"Prayer is from the heart. Prayer is a biblical obligation on a daily basis. Prayer is about self-change. And prayer is at its best when you do it for yourself."

Coming Up

- **Next week:** no shiur, as it is Hanukkah. Happy Hanukkah.
- **In two weeks:** the history of **Pesukei DeZimrah**, the songs of praise, and **Nishmat**.

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